

Story1

The old couple shuffled down the sidewalk, hands clasped, bracing each other against the chilly air. There was something mesmerizing about their slow, unsteady gait, the way they leaned into each other with each step.

I found myself following behind them, captivated for reasons I couldn't quite place. They turned down a tree-lined street and arrived at a little bungalow with yellow trim. The man fished a set of keys out of his coat pocket and opened the front door, its creak announcing their arrival. As they disappeared inside, I lingered under a large oak across the street.

Night was falling fast and hard; the sky had turned the ominous gray-green of an approaching storm. The wind started howling, shaking the branches of the trees. Something stirred in my memory - hadn't we passed a large armchair discarded on the sidewalk a few blocks back, its floral upholstery charred and crumbling? There had been something disturbingly familiar about that chair. I searched back beyond the faded memories of my current lifetime, straining further, delving into the deepest recesses of my mind - but the meaning of the chair eluded me. I racked my brain for hours under that oak tree hoping to unlock the secrets behind that armchair.

The blanket of night had descended upon the street. All I knew was that I felt drawn to that house and could not leave until the secrets hidden within revealed themselves. A few lights flickered on in the bungalow. Through lace curtains I could make out the old couple moving about leisurely preparing a home cooked meal, sitting down to eat, laughing and talking with ease and familiarity. A fierce fondness for these strangers swelled in my chest, and for the first time in most of my memory I felt a wave of melancholy and homesickness.

The rain began to pelt me as I hid under the tree. Soaked through and through, I pressed my face up against the cold glass of the window, peering into their home. Their conversation was muted through the glass but I could feel the warmth of their bond, the unconditional love and understanding borne of a lifetime together. A lifetime I had once shared with them, before my quick passing. The discarded armchair lingered at the edge of my thoughts, its ruined remains refusing to be forgotten.

Rain began to fall, first in wayward spatters then in unfettered sheets. Within minutes, water rushed down the street, pooling around my ankles. I should leave, I knew, head home before the flooding worsened. But I remained anchored to the spot, possessed by an irresistible desire to unlock the meaning of that armchair and understand my connection with the old couple. How had I stumbled upon again these people I loved so deeply in life? Had I finally come home in death?

The rain soaked through my clothes as I shivered in the cold, but still I could not turn away. They finished their meal and drew the curtains. Time stretched on as I stood half-concealed under drooping oak branches, kept company only by the steady crash of rain. What was this hold they had over me? Memories welled

up and flooded my senses. I remembered vacations by the sea, laughter over family dinners, quiet moments and deep conversations. A lifetime of memories I thought lost forever in the abyss of death came rushing back to me in that moment.

As the floodwaters rose to my knees, then my waist, understanding began to dawn - hazy and impossible and yet undeniable. The water rose higher and higher, but my feet remained stuck in place, as if held there by an unseen force awaiting redemption. I knew then with utter certainty that my wandering spirit would find peace only when the last of the secrets hidden within that little yellow house were laid bare.

The woman offered me a sad, knowing smile. I gazed into her eyes, eyes I knew as well as my own, and in them saw reflected the lifetime we had shared - and lost. My heart swelled near to bursting. And then, with their house crumbling into the hungry flood behind them, my parents turned and walked away into the rain. Leaving me once more alone, clinging to memories of a life now forever lost. The waters continued to rise around me but I could not follow. My spirit remained tethered to the earth, my penance unfinished, my rest unearned. The discarded chair lingered at the edge of my thoughts, a ruined reminder of a past forever out of reach. I called out to them but the churning waters muffled my cries. And as the flood swallowed me whole, I awoke with a start in my bed, my heart pounding, tears streaming down my face. The dream had felt so real. I knew then that I had been given a chance to make peace with my past and found closure at last. My restless spirit had come home.

-----The End-----

Story2

I saw the couple out of the corner of my eye. I noticed them as I stepped out of a medical building. I noticed them because everything else in my peripheral vision shifted but they did not. The wind was blowing the leaves, the leaves were dying and leaping, and the couple was so still. The couple was unmoving. I was, too, looking at them. So it was the three of us as everything else moved, constant and full and wide. People brushed by our shoulders, sweeping our sides as they strode toward their destinations. People were busy. People didn't care about the couple standing in the middle of the uneven sidewalk. People stirred around them like the sea, splashing against their ankles.

The man held her arms, his manicured fingers grasping hard.

Near the couple, there was a burned chair: garbage, darkened wood, charred remnants. That's what had attracted my attention while I was leaving the building, the medical building, with the activated charcoal in my teeth—an abandoned chair all broken at the hips.

I imagined the impulse of someone purchasing a new chair, deciding to throw this old one away—picking it up with their knees bent and their lower back engaged, a contraction in the abdomen, separating it from their other possessions, and this

object (made only for laziness or rest or gathering) being moved down a flight of wooden steps, being carried and offered to this sidewalk, sloppily, an old chair left to perish, and I imagined, too, the person who might have burned it, probably a man (men expect things to have violent ends) with a lighter or a match and the smell of a cigarette on his thumbs.

The dead chair was near the unmoving couple.

There was a balance there that I found significant, so I looked back and forth between them for six minutes, or seven. I knew the couple must have liked each other. They stared like children and kissed on the corners of their lips, and I knew.

If I followed the couple home, it was because of her hair. The building they entered was severe: red brick, steel, iron, and glass. Ugly. I waited to see what would become of them, now that they were inside a familiar place. Time passed, and it began to rain. I thought of the burned chair sitting outside the medical building, the consequence of this location, its wooden frame peeling. When the light turned on in the fourth window from the right, on the second floor, I felt relief. I became aroused. There was sweat, sweat on my nose, and my bowels were ready. There was water—the rain that was still coming down and the sweat that was still coming.

We were a triangle.

In the fourth window from the right, I saw pieces of them: the corner of a yellow painting, a bookcase filled to the brim, the light fixture, the tip of a houseplant's leaf, a purple sofa, the blue walls, and then finally, finally her face in the window, her hair, her closed eyes, his hand wrapped around her neck like a scarf.

Hers was a plain face, really, as unremarkable as a piece of furniture. A face marked with freckles.

She had the most average of lips, the dark right eyebrow, and the left just as dark, long eyelashes, a nose with a bump in the middle as if it had been broken in childhood, the freckles covering her cheekbones like sand, and her resting eyelids.

I couldn't see her eyes.

So I waited to see how long she would stay, unsmiling. The rain fell hard on my hands.

Her skin, her hair had distracted me.

It was the curl of it on her neck and on her forehead, the way it looked like a question mark, circuitous and pleading. It was the hair that had caused me to follow, to walk closely behind and wait on the street as they shuffled for their keys, the locks clicking and unclicking, their wrists turning, pressing their shoulders into doors, stumbling in, laughing, her name being called, Cannella,

it sounded like Cannella, Can—cursing, letting the door slam, fast, fast up the flight of stairs, taking two steps at a time.

It made me stay longer than expected, and the rain wouldn't stop. The rain continued. It felt heavy on my shoulders, and it rose. The water reached the backs of my knees, a flooding.

I did not think to leave, instead I walked back and forth in it, in front of the red brick, steel, iron, and glass building, her building, and in the middle of the street, which now looked like a swamp.

The gathering water rose to my thighs. It smelled of things in the moment before their dying. Objects floated past me—empty condom wrappers and large pears and extension cords, wet books full of soft paper (paper like cotton), nail clippers, peppermints, plastic spoons, dead mice, jars of unopened whipped honey. Rising water. This flood wasn't like the ocean, but I pretended that it was. I kicked my legs. Waves formed, the current was taking me, and the rain wet my hands.

Floating, I looked at the fourth window from the right. The couple resembled a photograph, so still, the man's manicured hand, his beautiful hand, on the neck of the woman, her eyes shut, and her dark eyebrows reaching up in mild surprise.

I don't know how long she stayed like that, unmoving, but we must have been a sight to see—the current pulling, the thunder, me almost submerged, but looking up, up, staring at the glass, at this person with the closed eyes and the imploring hair, the neck, freckles everywhere, skin like a burned chair.

-----The End-----

Story3

One morning in May, in a street not far from the river, I found myself following a young couple who were walking as if the essence of life lay in front of them. Wherever they stepped, the sun became brighter, the air more scented, and people broke into a smile without knowing why. A cab splashed mud on them; they laughed and kissed. Didn't they see that the world was in ruins? That the citadel was coming down around their ears? A rusty van quivered past, loaded with scrap metal; then a wail, longer and more lugubrious than seemed bearable, rose up from the ruins and with a shudder collapsed; the sun winked over Barnabas Buildings, emerging for a moment from the great gulf of the darkness where it had been travelling since creation and, emerging with a little grin, looked down from its slit in the sky.

The couple turned the corner; so did I; and there was the river. A robin hopped from branch to branch among the wattled fence that was her own particular settlement and probably will be for centuries to come. Now the sun, which was old and tumbled like a clown across the great countryside of the clouds, splashed them—for trees were now in leaf—and they blazed out, like a shop

window, green; and then were dark again, more dark than ever, since they had been green. There was a scullery smell, a smell of dumplings and dish-cloths, rising like steam from the earth; and one grape hyacinth lay crumpled in the grass; and all this great landscape was contained in a cracked looking-glass that leaned against a wall. But these were not the things the young couple had eyes for.

Suddenly a little terrier spotted them, cast up its hind legs like a leaping fish, and barked. They stopped. Now they were bending down; now the terrier was taken out, sniffing and shouting as if its duty lay in seeing that the couple before it were truly of the breed; and then the front door closed gently upon them and they were gone.

I stood by the railing looking at the geraniums, the river, the rusty van, and the little knob of glass that at this moment resembled a seal's eye. The stranger knocked me sideways. There was an altercation. The seal rolled from its perch; the water swirled round it; the wind screamed; the terrier barked; and as if all distractions were thus swept from between us, I saw indubitably for the first time and then forever the sight that no mortal eye has seen—the sight that is given to that bird flying with twitched wings, to the gull in the crash of waters, to the invisible owl—but never to a human being, blinded by the mist, buried in the fog, plunged into water, isolated in the crowd. And a great shiver shook the skeleton of the world and little silver bullets splintered in the air.

My head was wet. My socks were wet. My hands were shivering. I had stepped back—I had stepped into something cold and silky—to ice on a slope—and the smooth deep surface yielded to my feet and received me and supported me—I was upright and yet lying horizontally in the space far away from here. And as I stood there, shivering, I remembered quite distinctly what Maggie had said: We shan't be able to buy a new chair after all.

I wandered along the path that followed the curve of the river. The sight of a damaged chair propped against the wall burned into my memory. Scorch marks across its once elegant floral pattern told a tale of misery and abandonment. O, could that be the new chair Maggie spoke of? My curiosity left me no choice but to quench it by discovering more about this enigmatic couple. I soon found myself standing in front of their peeling blue door.

Through the window, I saw the young couple, Maggie and Tom, enveloped in a mundane domesticity; their voices floated into an idyllic tune as they spoke about the bills, the window latch that was stuck, and the leaking roof. The terrier sat upright on the rug, the perfect picture themselves – but I remained fixated on the image of that burned chair.

And suddenly, the sun was gone. A dense pall of rain clouds began to gather, gradually strangling the warmth of the sun. A storm had arrived.

The river swelled; massive feathery heaps of filthy foam dashed their banks. Gusts of wind surged through the city, an orchestra of alien harmonies accom-

panying the staccato of rain.

Inside, the couple stood still in the room, unaware of the menacing current of the river about to make their house its own. Phone lines snapped, their voices and laughter trapped within the four walls. On and on rose the water, like a swirling serpent with malicious intent. The face of their mantel clock submerged in the cold embrace, stopped ticking for eternity. Maggie lit a candle, casting a grave halo over the scene, much like the flame that had consumed the discarded chair.

I recalled the sunlit destruction and the couple's laughter in the street. I looked back at the submerged house. I stood waiting as the river climbed higher and their oblivious happiness dampened under the influence of nature's relentless wrath. And as she approached the window, a specter of the chair imprinted on her drained face, the connection dawned upon me: Maggie was the burned chair. Life had scorched her blooming spirit, but somehow the remnants of that joy still perpetuated, like a phoenix from the ashes, rising stronger and more resilient.

Amidst the haphazard chaos, a strong gust of wind pushed the waterlogged door, making it creak open. And as if they garnered the key to life's mysteries, they became aware of their perilous state. Panic gleamed in Maggie's eyes. Tom grabbed her hand and the terrier between them.

They were no longer the blissful canvas that I had seen earlier. Their soaked forms aggressively dragged by the capricious flood stood testament to the complexities of human emotions. The aftermath of the storm would leave them vulnerable, but it's the reminiscence of their buoyant spirits that will fuel them to live another day.

As the young couple fled from the flood, I began my retreat with a whisper, "Go now, Maggie, and find solace in the beauty of your resilience.

-----The End-----

Story4

The rain had been falling relentlessly for days, casting a gloomy haze over the city. Streets turned into rivers, and buildings threatened to be swallowed up by the rising floodwaters. Amidst this chaos, Evelyn, a keen observer, found herself captivated by a seemingly ordinary couple on the street.

She first noticed them while seeking refuge under the awning of a café. They strolled hand in hand, their steps perfectly synchronized as if they were connected by an invisible thread. Their smiles radiated warmth, unaffected by the bleak weather. Something about their simple yet undeniable connection caught Evelyn's attention.

Curiosity sparked within Evelyn, urging her to follow them. She trailed behind, careful not to arouse suspicion. They led her through narrow alleyways and labyrinthine streets until they arrived at a modest, dilapidated apartment

building. Without hesitation, they disappeared through the rusted metal gate, their laughter mingling with the sound of raindrops.

Evelyn hesitated, unsure if she should intrude upon the couple's private life. But something compelled her forward. She tiptoed through the puddles, her eyes fixed on what lay beyond the threshold of their home.

The couple's apartment was sparsely furnished, with peeling wallpaper and a dusty ambiance that mirrored the city's melancholy. Yet, amidst this desolation, there was a strange allure. The flickering lamplight cast eerie shadows upon the walls, serving as a backdrop to the couple's passionate embraces.

Evelyn found herself drawn to a corner of the room, where an oddity awaited her gaze. A ruined chair, charred and discarded, sat in silence. Its presence in the room seemed out of place, a stark contrast to the hopeful energy emanating from its inhabitants.

Night fell, and the rain intensified. As the floodwaters slowly seeped into the streets, Evelyn, driven by a mysterious fascination, sought refuge behind a lamp-post outside the couple's apartment building. From this vantage point, she watched the rising waters, her eyes fixed on the illuminated window of their world.

The couple's foreheads rested against the glass, their breath leaving foggy imprints in the cold air. Their bodies moved with a fluidity that was both mesmerizing and peculiarly synchronized. It was as if they were dancing with the storm, an unspoken connection binding them together.

Meanwhile, the water continued its relentless ascent, threatening to swallow the city whole. Evelyn's heart raced, torn between fascination and concern. She couldn't tear her gaze away from the couple, as if they were reflections of a forgotten etching in her memory.

As dawn broke, the rain finally ceased, leaving behind a desolate aftermath. Entire streets were submerged, cars turned into forgotten relics, and the world outside seemed suspended in eerie stillness. But within the apartment, the couple's embrace remained unyielding, as if they were the only beings capable of defying the chaos.

With the storm finally abated, Evelyn emerged from her hiding place, compelled to confront the enigma she had been drawn into. As she stood outside their door, a chilling realization washed over her. The burnt chair she had observed earlier, expelled and forgotten, held an inexplicable connection to the woman.

Evelyn, trembling with a mixture of fear and anticipation, reached out to knock on their door. But before her knuckles could make contact, the door swung open, revealing the couple standing before her. Their eyes held a wisdom that transcended their years, as if they had weathered the storm countless times before.

Without uttering a word, the woman extended a hand toward Evelyn, inviting her into their world. It was a silent invitation to embrace the enigmatic connection she felt, to dance with them in the face of the unforgiving storm.

And so, in a city awoken by catastrophe, a discarded chair, a couple entwined in ethereal dance, and an observer entranced by it all, converged. The floodwaters had receded, but a deeper connection had risen from the depths of chaos, forever etching itself into the fabric of their lives.

Evelyn stepped across the threshold, venturing into the sanctuary of their apartment. The couple welcomed her with open arms, as if they had been awaiting her arrival. They introduced themselves as Clara and Samuel, two wanderers who found solace in the art of connection.

As the days turned into weeks, Evelyn became an integral part of their unconventional trio. They explored the city together, venturing into the remains left in the wake of the storm. Each crumbling building and shattered window held a story, waiting to be discovered.

With Clara as their guide, Evelyn and Samuel embarked on a journey to capture the essence of the city in their photographs. Through the lens, they discovered hidden pockets of beauty amidst the destruction. Their images spoke volumes, capturing the resilience and indomitable spirit of the human soul.

As time passed, Evelyn's fascination with the burnt chair grew. Its presence haunted her dreams, a symbol of strength and survival amidst the chaos. She embarked on a quest to uncover its origins, tracing its history through fragments of memories shared by the city's inhabitants.

One day, while exploring an abandoned library, Evelyn stumbled upon a weathered notebook. Its pages were filled with sketches and poems, recounting the tale of a couple who forged an unbreakable bond in the midst of a devastating fire. The story echoed the experiences of Clara and Samuel, hinting at a connection that spanned generations.

Evelyn shared her discovery with her newfound companions, and together, they pieced together the forgotten narrative of the chair. They learned that it had once belonged to Clara's grandparents, who had faced unimaginable hardships caused by the fire, just as Clara and Samuel had faced the storm.

In an act of homage and reverence, Clara and Samuel decided to restore the chair, breathing new life into its charred remains. It became a symbol of their resilience, a testament to their unyielding connection in the face of adversity.

As they unveiled the restored chair, the city came alive with a newfound sense of hope. People from all walks of life gathered to witness Clara and Samuel's journey, inspired by their unwavering love and the beauty they had found amidst the ruins.

Together, they transformed the dilapidated apartment building into a sanctuary of creativity and connection. The couple's ethereal dances infused life into the

forgotten corners, while Evelyn's photographs adorned the walls, immortalizing the stories she had captured.

The trio's sanctuary became a beacon of inspiration, inviting others to embrace the enigma of the burnt chair and dance with them in the face of life's storms.

And so, as the rain clouds receded and sunlight bathed the city once more, a community bound by resilience and connection emerged. They had weathered the storms of life, finding solace in the thread that connected them all - the enduring power of human connection.

-----The End-----